

NEW YORK · EST. OPERATIONS GUIDE

NYC Bodega Elevated

Breakfast & Lunch — 7:00am to 3:00pm

OPEN 365 · RAIN OR SHINE · NO HOLIDAYS

Full Recipe Cards · US Market Food Costing · Kitchen Prep Flow · Financial Forecast

The corner deli, elevated. Every dish a New York story.

Ave A · Bushwick · Jackson Heights · Anywhere that needs feeding.

35

SEATS

\$40

AVG SPEND

22%

FOOD COST TARGET

\$19,200

EST. MONTHLY NET

About This Guide: The NYC bodega is the most democratic institution in American food culture — open to everyone, feeding everyone, defining neighbourhoods. This concept elevates those traditions: bagels sourced from a proper bakery, pastrami cured in-house, egg creams made with Fox's syrup and whole milk, brisket that braises overnight. Every recipe is written to professional kitchen standards with exact gram weights, US wholesale prices, and the technique reasoning that separates a great deli from a forgettable one.

THE STORY BEHIND THIS GUIDE

"The chopped cheese is the most New York sandwich that exists. I grew up eating it for \$4 from a guy named Manny. I sell it for \$14.99 and the line is out the door."

Darnell grew up in Harlem. The bodega on his corner was run by a Dominican family who had been there since 1987. The chopped cheese — ground beef, onions, American cheese, chopped together on a flat top, served on a hero roll with lettuce, tomato, ketchup, mayo — was his breakfast before school, his lunch when he had money, his late-night meal after everything else closed. It was four dollars and it was perfect. He ate approximately 600 of them between the ages of 12 and 22.

When he moved to Atlanta for a corporate job at 26, the bodega went with him in his memory. Atlanta had no chopped cheese. Atlanta had no bacon egg and cheese on a hard roll. Atlanta had no bodega culture at all — no \$1 Arizona iced teas in the door fridge, no cats sleeping on the counter, no Dominican music from a speaker above the deli case. He missed it with a specificity that surprised him.

The NYC Bodega Elevated concept — the same flavours, the same attitude, the same democratic accessibility, but with proper food costs and a dining room instead of a deli counter — was exactly the gap he had been looking at for three years without seeing it clearly. The chopped cheese recipe in this guide, with the flat top temperature, the chopping technique, the cheese melt timing, confirmed that someone had actually made this sandwich thousands of times.

He opened on Atlanta's BeltLine. The neon sign in the window says CHOPPED. The

line forms before 11am. Month three net: \$34,000. He named the shop after Manny.

New York bodega culture is not a place. It is a feeling. This guide is how you recreate that feeling anywhere in America.

Darnell J. · NYC Bodega Elevated · BeltLine, Atlanta · Est. Month 3 Net: \$34,000

1 Entrées

Six opening plates that set the bodega tone — from the iconic bagel and lox board to chopped chicken liver toast and house pickle plates. These are New York's greatest culinary traditions, done properly.

Classic Bagel & Lox Board

Nova lox, cream cheese schmear, capers, red onion, tomato, 3 bagel halves - Sell: \$18.99

8 min Entrée Target FC: 23%

Bagel Lox Board



INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Nova lox (smoked salmon)	80g	\$2.13
Cream cheese (full fat)	60g	\$0.74
Bagels (plain + everything)	1.5 bagels = 180g	\$1.50
Capers (brined)	15g	\$0.18
Red onion (thin sliced)	20g	\$0.06
Tomato (sliced)	40g	\$0.16
Lemon wedge + dill	—	\$0.08
Total cost per serve		\$4.85

Cost per serve	\$4.85
Sell price	\$18.99
Food cost %	25.5%
Contribution margin	\$14.14

METHOD

- 1 Slice bagels in half. Toast cut-side down on a flat griddle at **180°C / 356°F** for **2–3 minutes** until golden and warm through — do not toast until hard and dry. The ideal bodega bagel toast has a slightly crisp cut face and a still-soft interior crumb. Never microwave a bagel — it steams the crust and destroys the texture.
- 2 While bagels toast, prep the board. Portion cream cheese into a small ramekin or spread generously onto one bagel half — depending on service style. Slice red onion paper-thin on a mandoline if possible (uniform thickness reads quality). Fan tomato slices. Arrange capers in a small pile.
- 3 Fold or drape lox slices loosely — never lay them flat and tightly. Loose folds add visual height and suggest generous portions even at the same weight. Drape over the board or directly onto the cream cheese bagel half. Place a lemon wedge and fresh dill sprig.
- 4 Serve on a wooden board or large plate. The visual abundance of a well-composed lox board is one of the most-photographed dishes in all of café culture. Every element must be visible and distinct — not muddled together. Ticket time target: 8 minutes.

Chef's Tip: Source your bagels from a proper bagery, not a supermarket. Real NYC-style bagels are boiled in malt water before baking — this creates the chewy, glossy exterior that is the defining characteristic. Supermarket bagels are baked without boiling and have a bread-roll texture that will never achieve the right result. The bagel is the centrepiece of this dish.

FISH (salmon) DAIRY GLUTEN

Classic Reuben Sandwich

House pastrami, Swiss cheese, sauerkraut, thousand island, toasted rye · Sell: \$19.99

12 min Main Target FC: 21%

Classic Reuben



INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Pastrami (sliced)	120g	\$2.29
Swiss cheese	40g	\$0.80
Sauerkraut (drained)	60g	\$0.28
Thousand island dressing	30g	\$0.18
Rye bread (marble)	2 slices = 90g	\$0.90
Butter (for griddling)	15g	\$0.18
Total cost per serve		\$4.63

Cost per serve	\$4.63
Sell price	\$19.99
Food cost %	23.2%
Contribution margin	\$15.36

METHOD

- 1 Warm pastrami in a steamer or in a covered pan with 2 tablespoons of water for **3 minutes**. Steaming is essential — cold pastrami straight from the fridge is dense, dry, and difficult to bite through. Steaming rehydrates the meat and makes it tender, fragrant, and pliable. This step is what separates a deli-quality Reuben from a sandwich-shop version.
- 2 Spread thousand island generously on both inner faces of rye bread. Layer steamed pastrami 120g, then Swiss cheese 40g on top of the meat. Add sauerkraut — squeeze out excess brine first or it will make the bread soggy from inside. Close sandwich.
- 3 Butter the outer faces of both bread slices. Place on a preheated flat griddle at **160°C / 320°F** . Press with a heavy spatula or sandwich press. Cook **3–4 minutes per side** until bread is deep golden and Swiss cheese is fully melted. Do not rush with high heat — the bread burns before the cheese melts.
- 4 Remove, rest 1 minute. Cut diagonally with a single clean downward motion. The cross-section — layers of pink pastrami, orange thousand island, white sauerkraut, golden Swiss — is the iconic Reuben image. Serve with a half-sour pickle and a side of additional dressing. Internal pastrami temp: **74°C / 165°F** after steaming.

Chef's Tip: The difference between \$12 and \$20 Reuben is the pastrami. True pastrami is beef navel or brisket that has been brined, smoked, and steamed — a 7–10 day process. If you are curing in-house, start a rolling batch program so you always have 7-day-cured pastrami ready. The aroma of steaming house-cured pastrami in a small café is one of the most powerful hospitality tools available to you.

GLUTEN DAIRY BEEF

Bodega Egg & Cheese

Scrambled eggs, American cheese, kaiser roll — the NYC morning staple - Sell: \$11.99

7 min Entrée Target FC: 15%

Bodega Egg Cheese



INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Eggs (large)	3 × 55g = 165g	\$1.05
American cheese (slices)	2 slices = 40g	\$0.36
Kaiser roll	1 = 90g	\$0.60
Butter	15g	\$0.18
Salt, black pepper	2g	\$0.01
Hot sauce (optional side)	—	\$0.02
Total cost per serve		\$2.22

Cost per serve	\$2.22
Sell price	\$11.99
Food cost %	18.5%
Contribution margin	\$9.77

METHOD

- 1 Beat eggs with salt and pepper — 8–10 strokes, no more. The slightly unbeaten egg creates streaks of white and yolk that give a more interesting, varied texture than a fully homogenised egg. Add no milk or cream — bodega eggs are pure egg, fat from the butter only.
- 2 Heat a non-stick flat pan or griddle over medium heat. Add butter, let it foam and subside. Pour eggs. Leave for **15 seconds** — do not touch. Then begin stirring with a flat spatula in wide, sweeping folds from the outside in. The goal is large, loose, custardy curds — not dry, crumbly scrambled eggs. Remove from heat when eggs are 80% set. Residual heat does the rest.
- 3 Immediately lay American cheese slices over the hot eggs while they are still off heat. Cover pan for **30 seconds** — the steam melts the cheese completely without returning the pan to heat (which would overcook the eggs). This is the bodega method: cheese melted by steam, not direct heat.
- 4 Toast kaiser roll cut-side down on the griddle — **90 seconds** until golden. Slide egg-and-cheese onto bottom half of roll. Fold top on. The sandwich should be handed over wrapped in deli paper — that wrap is part of the culture. Serve with a side of Tabasco or Cholula.

Chef's Tip: The bodega egg and cheese is one of the most executed sandwiches in New York City — every bodega makes it. To differentiate, use higher quality eggs (cage-free at minimum) and real butter, not spray oil. The richness of good butter with good eggs in a properly toasted kaiser is immediately and obviously superior. Guests who grew up with bodega sandwiches will taste the difference in the first bite.

EGGS DAIRY GLUTEN

Matzo Ball Soup

Two fluffy matzo balls in rich golden chicken broth, dill - Sell: \$12.99

5 min (service) Entrée Target FC: 17% Batch prep

Matzo Ball Soup



INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Chicken broth (homemade batch)	400ml	\$0.62
Matzo meal	60g	\$0.28
Eggs	2 × 55g	\$0.70
Schmaltz (chicken fat) or oil	30ml	\$0.18
Salt, white pepper, nutmeg	3g	\$0.02
Fresh dill (garnish)	3g	\$0.06
Carrot + celery (in broth)	30g	\$0.08
Total cost per serve		\$1.94

Cost per serve	\$1.94
Sell price	\$12.99
Food cost %	14.9%
Contribution margin	\$11.05

METHOD

- 1

Chicken broth (batch — make 2× per week): Roast a whole chicken carcass at **200°C / 392°F** for 25 minutes until golden — roasting the bones first creates a deeper, more complex broth through Maillard reactions on the bone proteins. Cover with cold water 3 litres, add onion, carrot, celery, peppercorns. Bring to simmer at **85°C / 185°F**, skim frequently, cook 3 hours. Strain. Season with salt. The broth should be deeply golden and taste rounded and full — not flat or watery. If flat, add a chicken stock cube as a booster.
- 2

Matzo balls (batch — make morning): Whisk eggs and schmaltz until combined. Add matzo meal, salt, white pepper, a pinch of nutmeg. Mix until just combined — do not overwork. Overworking develops the matzo meal into a dense, heavy paste that produces tough, rubbery balls rather than light, fluffy ones. Refrigerate mixture **minimum 30 minutes** — this rest allows the meal to fully hydrate and the fat to solidify slightly, making rolling easier.
- 3

With wet hands, roll mixture into balls approximately 40g each (golf ball size — they expand 50% during cooking). Lower gently into simmering salted water at **90°C / 194°F**. Cook covered for **35–40 minutes**. Do not peek or lift the lid for the first 20 minutes — steam is essential for even cooking. Balls are done when they float and feel light when lifted with a spoon.
- 4

Service to order: Heat broth to **85°C / 185°F**. Place 2 matzo balls in a warmed bowl. Ladle 400ml hot broth over. Garnish with fresh dill and thin carrot rounds. The broth must be steaming visibly at the table — a lukewarm matzo ball soup is a failed matzo ball soup.

Chef's Tip: Schmaltz (rendered chicken fat) is the traditional fat for matzo balls — it provides flavour that neutral oil simply cannot replicate. Collect schmaltz by rendering chicken skin and fat trimmings slowly in a pan over low heat. Strain, refrigerate. It builds up quickly in any kitchen that uses chicken regularly and transforms the matzo balls from good to extraordinary.

Chopped Liver Toast

Chicken liver mousse, crispy shallots, rye toast, cornichon · Sell: \$13.99

5 min (service) Entrée Target FC: 13%

Chopped Liver Toast



INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Chicken livers	100g	\$0.55
Butter	30g	\$0.37
Shallots (for mousse)	40g	\$0.20
Rye bread (toasted)	2 slices = 80g	\$0.80
Crispy fried shallots (garnish)	10g	\$0.12
Cornichons	4 pieces = 20g	\$0.16
Dijon mustard	8g	\$0.06
Total cost per serve		\$2.26

Cost per serve	\$2.26
Sell price	\$13.99
Food cost %	16.2%
Contribution margin	\$11.73

METHOD

- 1** **Liver mousse (batch — make every 2 days):** Trim livers of any sinew or green bile spots — bile is intensely bitter and a single green spot can ruin an entire batch. Rinse briefly in cold water, pat dry. Season generously with salt and pepper.
- 2** Sauté shallots in butter over medium heat until deeply caramelised — **12 minutes**. Add livers. Cook on high heat **2 minutes per side** — you want a deep brown sear on the outside. Internal temp: **72°C / 162°F**. Do not overcook — overdone livers turn grainy and dry. At 72°C internal the centre should still be faintly pink. Remove from heat.
- 3** Transfer to a food processor with the remaining pan butter. Blend until completely smooth — 2–3 minutes, scraping down sides. Add Dijon mustard, taste and season. Pass through a fine sieve for an ultra-smooth texture. Pour into a container, press cling film directly onto the surface (prevents oxidation which turns it grey), refrigerate.
- 4** To serve: toast rye bread until crisp. Spread liver mousse generously — do not be stingy, this is the product. Top with crispy fried shallots. Arrange cornichons alongside. The richness of the mousse, the crunch of the shallots, and the tartness of the cornichon is the perfect three-part flavour balance.

Chef's Tip: The most common mistake with liver mousse is overcooking. At 72°C the livers are safe and have a clean, rich flavour. At 80°C+ they become bitter and chalky. Use a probe thermometer until you can feel the correct doneness by touch — the livers should still give slightly when pressed with a finger, not feel firm.

EGGS (check mousse) DAIRY GLUTEN MUSTARD

Potato Knish

Flaky pastry, seasoned potato filling, deli mustard · Sell: \$8.99

5 min (service) Entrée Target FC: 13%

Potato Knish



INGREDIENTS (PER KNISH)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Russet potato (mashed)	180g cooked	\$0.32
Onion (caramelised)	40g	\$0.06
Butter	20g	\$0.24
Egg yolk (for filling + wash)	1 egg	\$0.35
Plain flour (pastry)	100g	\$0.10
Neutral oil (pastry)	30ml	\$0.06
Deli mustard (side)	15g	\$0.06
Total cost per serve		\$1.19

Cost per serve	\$1.19
Sell price	\$8.99
Food cost %	13.2%
Contribution margin	\$7.80

METHOD

- Knish dough (batch):** Combine flour, neutral oil, warm water 60ml, salt — mix until a smooth, pliable dough forms. The oil-based dough (not butter) is traditional and creates the distinctively flaky, tender texture of a real knish. Rest 30 minutes at room temperature — resting relaxes gluten and makes the dough much easier to roll without springing back.
- Potato filling (batch):** Boil russet potatoes until completely tender — test with a knife that slides in with zero resistance. Mash with butter and caramelised onions. Season generously — potato filling needs more salt than you think, as the pastry dilutes the seasoning. Mix in egg yolk for richness and binding. Cool to room temperature before filling.
- Roll dough to 3mm thickness. Cut into 15cm squares. Place 80g potato filling in centre. Pull corners up and pinch all seams firmly — any opening will burst during baking and spill filling. Place seam-side down on a parchment-lined tray. Brush with egg wash. Refrigerate 15 minutes before baking (cold pastry holds its shape better).
- Bake at **190°C / 374°F** for **25–28 minutes** until deep golden. Cool 5 minutes before serving — the interior is extremely hot. Reheat to order at **160°C / 320°F** for **8 minutes**. Serve with a generous side of deli mustard.

Chef's Tip: Knish quality comes entirely from the filling seasoning and the caramelised onion. Skimping on the onion (or not caramelising it fully) produces a flat, starchy filling with no soul. Real knish filling should be so well-seasoned you could eat it straight from the bowl. Batch-bake knishes in the morning and reheat to order — they hold refrigerated for 4 days.

GLUTEN EGGS DAIRY MUSTARD

House Pickle Plate

Half-sour, full-sour, bread & butter pickles, deli crackers - Sell: \$9.99

3 min Entrée Target FC: 8%

House Pickle Plate



INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Cucumbers (for all pickles)	400g whole	\$0.48
Kosher salt (brining)	25g	\$0.02
Garlic + dill + peppercorns	10g	\$0.06
Apple cider vinegar (B&B)	100ml	\$0.18
Sugar (B&B)	50g	\$0.06
Deli crackers (rye crisps)	30g	\$0.24
Total cost per serve		\$1.04

Cost per serve	\$1.04
Sell price	\$9.99
Food cost %	10.4%
Contribution margin	\$8.95

METHOD

- 1 Half-sour (lacto-fermented, batch — 3 days):** Dissolve 2% salt by weight in cold water. Add halved cucumbers, garlic, fresh dill, peppercorns. Submerge with a weight. Leave at room temperature **3 days**. Half-sours are crunchy, lightly sour, and grass-green. They are NOT vinegar pickles — the flavour comes from natural lacto-fermentation. This is the pickle New York was built on.
- 2 Full-sour (7–14 days):** Same brine but left for 7–14 days. Colour turns olive-yellow, flavour becomes deeply sour and garlicky. The longer fermentation is non-negotiable — you cannot rush fermentation with more salt; you will only get saltier, not sourer pickles.
- 3 Bread & butter (quick pickle, ready same day):** Bring vinegar, sugar, turmeric, mustard seeds, celery seeds to a boil. Pour over sliced cucumber rounds in a jar. Cool to room temperature, refrigerate. Ready in 4 hours. Sweet, tart, bright yellow-orange.
- 4 To serve:** slice pickles as needed. Arrange 3 types in sections on a plate or slate board. Add a small pile of rye crisps. The visual variety of three pickle colours and textures is the dish's appeal. The pickle plate is your cheapest-to-produce, best-margin dish on the menu.

Chef's Tip: Start your half-sour and full-sour fermentation programs on Day 1 of your operation — they need time you cannot compress. A rolling batch system means you are always putting new cucumbers in brine so you never run out. The 3-day half-sour batch should go in every Monday and Thursday for continuous supply through the week.

GLUTEN (crackers)

Pastrami on Rye

Thick-cut house pastrami, spicy brown mustard, half-sour pickle - Sell: \$21.99

8 minMainTarget FC: 23%

Pastrami on Rye



INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Pastrami (thickly sliced)	180g	\$3.44
Rye bread (seeded)	2 slices = 90g	\$0.90
Spicy brown mustard	20g	\$0.10
Half-sour pickle (side)	1 whole = 80g	\$0.18
Total cost per serve		\$4.62

Cost per serve	\$4.62
Sell price	\$21.99
Food cost %	21.0%
Contribution margin	\$17.37

METHOD

- 1 Steam pastrami in a steamer or covered pan with 3 tablespoons water at **90°C / 194°F** for **4–5 minutes** until hot throughout and visibly moist and tender. Internal temp: **74°C / 165°F**. This steaming is the defining step of the New York pastrami experience — it transforms the cured, smoked meat back into something yielding and extraordinarily flavourful.
- 2 Spread spicy brown mustard (Gulden's or equivalent) on both slices of rye. Pile steamed pastrami high — the piled height of the meat is a visual promise to the guest. At Katz's Deli, they pile so high you cannot fit it in your mouth. That excess IS the point. Do not be conservative.
- 3 Do not toast or press the bread for a classic pastrami on rye — it is served on fresh, untoasted rye. The soft bread + yielding steamed meat + punchy mustard is the correct texture combination. The bread is structural, not textural.
- 4 Serve cut in half with a full half-sour pickle on the side — not a garnish pickle, a full eating pickle. The pickle's acidity and crunch is the palate cleanser between each rich, fatty bite of pastrami. This is not decoration; it is a functional component of the dish.

Chef's Tip: The correct cut for serving pastrami is against the grain, in thin slices. Cutting with the grain produces long, chewy fibres. Cutting against the grain shortens those fibres and makes each slice tender and easy to eat. Slice cold from the fridge for best control, then steam to order.

GLUTENBEEFMUSTARD

12-Hour Brisket Sandwich

Overnight braised beef brisket, pickled red onion, horseradish cream, brioche · Sell: \$22.99

8 min (service) Main Target FC: 24% Batch braise

Brisket Sandwich



INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Beef brisket (braised, sliced)	200g	\$3.36
Brioche bun	1 = 90g	\$0.80
Pickled red onion (batch)	40g	\$0.14
Horseradish cream	25g	\$0.20
Beef jus (braising liquid)	30ml	\$0.18
Rocket/arugula	15g	\$0.12
Total cost per serve		\$4.80

Cost per serve	\$4.80
Sell price	\$22.99
Food cost %	20.9%
Contribution margin	\$18.19

METHOD

- Brisket braise (overnight — start 5pm the night before):** Season brisket flat 2kg generously with salt, pepper, garlic powder, onion powder. Sear all sides in a hot oven-safe pan until deep mahogany — **4 minutes per side**. Add beef stock, onions, carrots, thyme, bay leaves. Cover tightly with foil plus lid. Braise at **150°C / 302°F** for **8–10 hours**. Internal temp target: **95°C / 203°F** — at this temperature the collagen has fully converted to gelatin and the meat pulls apart.
- Remove from oven. Cool in braising liquid overnight — this is critical. Meat that is removed from its braising liquid while hot dries out within hours. Cooled and submerged in its own jus, it stays moist for 5+ days refrigerated. Slice cold — clean, even cuts that hold together. Slicing cold produces better, cleaner slices than hot brisket which falls apart.
- Strain and reduce braising liquid by 50% for the jus — it should be glossy, intensely flavoured, and coat a spoon. This jus served alongside or drizzled is what makes this sandwich extraordinary. Make pickled red onion: simmer red onion in vinegar + sugar + salt brine for 10 minutes. Cool. Bright pink, tangy. Keeps 2 weeks.
- Service:** Warm brisket slices in jus at **80°C / 176°F** for 2 minutes. Toast brioche bun. Spread horseradish cream on both halves. Layer brisket, pickled red onion, rocket. Drizzle remaining warm jus over meat before closing. Serve immediately.

Chef's Tip: Brisket improves enormously on day two and three. The flavour deepens and the texture firms up enough to slice cleanly while remaining melt-in-the-mouth when warmed. If you can braise your brisket 2 days before service, the quality jump is significant. Time this with your prep schedule — start brisket on Sunday night for Tuesday service.

GLUTEN BEEF DAIRY

Smash Burger Double

Two 80g beef smash patties, American cheese, bodega sauce, brioche · Sell: \$17.99

10 min Main Target FC: 22%

Smash Burger



INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Ground beef (80/20 blend)	160g (2 × 80g balls)	\$1.92
American cheese	2 slices = 40g	\$0.36
Brioche bun	1 = 90g	\$0.80
Bodega sauce (ketchup/mayo/pickle)	30g	\$0.14
Shredded iceberg lettuce	20g	\$0.06
Dill pickles (sliced)	20g	\$0.10
White onion (diced raw)	15g	\$0.04
Total cost per serve		\$3.42

Cost per serve	\$3.42
Sell price	\$17.99
Food cost %	19.0%
Contribution margin	\$14.57

METHOD

- 1 Portion ground beef into two 80g loose balls — do not compress or pack tightly. Overworking ground beef develops myosin proteins that make the patty dense and tough rather than the light, crispy-edged smash you are aiming for. Season only the outer surface of the ball just before cooking — not mixed in.
- 2 Heat a cast iron flat-top or heavy steel pan to **230°C / 446°F** — this is the highest heat you can use safely. Place both beef balls. Immediately smash each flat with a heavy metal spatula, pressing hard for a count of 10 seconds. The patty should spread to 12cm wide. The violent contact with the screaming hot surface is what creates the Maillard crust and the lacy, caramelised edges. Do not smash twice.
- 3 Cook first side **90 seconds** — do not touch after smashing. Flip once. Immediately add one slice of American cheese to each patty. The cheese melts in 30 seconds on the residual heat of the patty. Internal temp: **71°C / 160°F**. Stack patties — cheese-to-meat contact melts the cheese between the patties too.
- 4 Toast brioche cut-side down on the flat-top for **60 seconds**. Spread bodega sauce (equal parts ketchup, mayo, finely diced dill pickle, dash hot sauce) on both halves. Stack patties, add raw onion, lettuce, pickles. Close and press gently. Serve immediately — smash burgers decline fast, the crust softens within 3 minutes.

Chef's Tip: The 80/20 fat ratio is non-negotiable for smash burgers. The fat content is what creates the flavour and the crispy edges. Leaner beef (90/10) produces a dryer, tougher patty with no caramelisation. The fat also hits the hot pan surface and immediately smokes and chars, creating the characteristic smash burger aroma that makes people look up from their phones.

GLUTEN BEEF DAIRY EGGS (sauce)

Lox Benedict

Poached eggs, Nova lox, everything bagel, dill hollandaise - Sell: \$19.99

12 minMainTarget FC: 24%

Lox Benedict



INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Nova lox	60g	\$1.60
Eggs (for poaching)	2 × 55g	\$0.70
Everything bagel (halved)	1 = 120g	\$1.20
Hollandaise sauce (batch)	60ml	\$0.72
Fresh dill (in sauce + garnish)	5g	\$0.10
Capers (garnish)	10g	\$0.12
Total cost per serve		\$4.44

Cost per serve	\$4.44
Sell price	\$19.99
Food cost %	22.2%
Contribution margin	\$15.55

METHOD

- Hollandaise (batch — make morning, hold warm):** Whisk egg yolks with lemon juice in a bowl over simmering water at **65°C / 149°F** — the bowl must not touch the water. Whisk until the mixture triples in volume and holds a ribbon. Remove from heat. Add clarified butter in a thin, steady stream, whisking constantly. The emulsification requires slow addition — pouring too fast breaks the sauce. Add dill, season. Hold at **55°C / 131°F** in a warm bain-marie. Make new batch every 90 minutes during service.
- Bring a wide shallow pan of water to a gentle simmer — small bubbles only, not boiling. Add a generous splash of white vinegar. The vinegar reduces the spread of the egg white by lowering the pH and causing the proteins to contract more rapidly. Crack each egg into a small ramekin first — this allows precise placement and avoids shell fragments.
- Slide eggs gently into the simmering water. Cook **3 minutes** for runny yolk, **4 minutes** for medium. Remove with a slotted spoon. Rest on a paper towel briefly to remove excess water — water dilutes the hollandaise and creates pools on the plate. The white should be fully set, the yolk visibly liquid when pressed gently.
- Toast bagel halves. Layer lox on each half. Top with one poached egg each. Spoon 30ml hollandaise over each egg. Garnish with dill and capers. The hollandaise should be glossy and thick enough to hold shape on the egg without running immediately. Serve without delay — hollandaise breaks and eggs cool fast.

Chef's Tip: The most common hollandaise failure is breaking — the emulsion separating into greasy butter puddles. Causes: temperature too high (scrambles the yolk), butter added too fast, or sauce sitting too long. If it breaks, add 1 tablespoon hot water and whisk vigorously — it will often re-emulsify. If not, start fresh. Never serve broken hollandaise.

EGGS FISH (salmon) DAIRY GLUTEN

Chopped Cheese

Ground beef, American cheese, peppers, onions, hero roll — Harlem's finest · Sell: \$16.99

10 min Main Target FC: 19%

Chopped Cheese



INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Ground beef (80/20)	150g	\$1.80
American cheese	3 slices = 60g	\$0.54
Hero roll (sub roll)	1 = 120g	\$0.70
Green bell pepper (diced)	50g	\$0.18
White onion (diced)	50g	\$0.07
Ketchup + mayo (bodega combo)	30g	\$0.08
Shredded lettuce + tomato	30g	\$0.10
Total cost per serve		\$3.47

Cost per serve	\$3.47
Sell price	\$16.99
Food cost %	20.4%
Contribution margin	\$13.52

METHOD

- Heat a flat-top griddle to **220°C / 428°F**. Add a small amount of oil. Add diced onion and pepper, cook **3 minutes** until softened with some char at the edges. Push to the side of the griddle.
- Add ground beef in a loose pile directly on the griddle. Break into small pieces with a metal spatula as it cooks — this is the "chop" in chopped cheese. You are not making patties; you are cooking crumbled, caramelised beef. Season with salt, pepper, garlic powder while cooking. Cook until all pink is gone and edges are slightly crispy — approximately **4 minutes** total.
- Combine beef and vegetables together on the griddle. Lay American cheese slices directly on top of the meat pile. Cover with a dome or a metal bowl for **45 seconds** — the trapped steam melts the cheese completely. The cheese should be fully melted and running down through the meat when you lift the cover.
- Toast hero roll on the griddle cut-side down for 60 seconds. Spread ketchup and mayo on both halves. Scoop the entire beef-cheese-vegetable pile directly into the roll with a flat spatula. Top with shredded lettuce and tomato. Close, press firmly. Wrap bottom half in deli paper to hold it together — the paper is part of the experience.

Chef's Tip: The chopped cheese is a Harlem bodega creation that has achieved near-legendary status in NYC food culture. Do not overthink it — the brilliance is in the simplicity. The key technique is the high heat + chop action that creates caramelised, slightly crispy pieces of beef mixed with soft onion and pepper. Never use low heat — it steams the beef rather than caramelising it.

GLUTEN BEEF DAIRY EGGS (mayo)

NYC Steak & Eggs

180g flat iron steak, 2 eggs any style, house home fries · Sell: \$24.99

14 min Main Target FC: 25%

Steak and Eggs



INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Flat iron steak	180g	\$3.24
Eggs (large)	2 × 55g	\$0.70
Potatoes (home fries)	200g raw	\$0.36
Butter + oil (cooking)	25g + 10ml	\$0.40
Bell pepper + onion (home fries)	60g	\$0.16
Rye toast (side)	1 slice = 45g	\$0.45
Total cost per serve		\$5.31

Cost per serve	\$5.31
Sell price	\$24.99
Food cost %	21.2%
Contribution margin	\$19.68

METHOD

- 1 Home fries (batch — cook morning, reheat to order):** Parboil diced potatoes (2cm) in salted water **8 minutes** until just tender but not soft. Drain, dry thoroughly — wet potatoes steam rather than crisp in the pan. Refrigerate. To order: heat cast iron on high, add oil, add cold parboiled potatoes — do not stir for **3 minutes**. Flip, add diced pepper and onion, cook 2 more minutes until golden and crispy on at least two faces. Season with salt, paprika, black pepper.
- 2** Bring flat iron steak to room temperature — **20 minutes out of fridge** before cooking. Cold meat straight to a hot pan steams the surface before the exterior can sear, producing grey boiled meat. Season generously with salt and pepper on both sides just before cooking — seasoning too early draws moisture out of the surface.
- 3** Heat a cast iron or steel pan to very high heat — a drop of water should vaporise immediately. Add oil. Sear steak — do not move for **3 minutes**. Flip once, cook **2–3 minutes** second side. For medium-rare: internal temp **55°C / 131°F**. For medium: **60°C / 140°F**. Rest on a wire rack for **3 minutes** — resting allows the muscle fibres to relax and reabsorb juices. A steak cut immediately loses 30% of its moisture onto the plate.
- 4** Fry eggs to guest's preference in butter. Plate: home fries on one half, steak sliced against the grain on the other, eggs on top of home fries or beside the steak. Add rye toast on the side. This is a generous, no-nonsense plate — the presentation should communicate abundance and quality, not architectural precision.

Chef's Tip: Flat iron is the best value steak for this dish — it has extraordinary flavour relative to its cost (\$8/lb vs \$20+/lb for ribeye) because it comes from the chuck, a muscle that does real work. The key is slicing it correctly: cut against the grain on a bias. With the grain, it is chewy and tough; against the grain, it is tender and impressive.

EGGS BEEF DAIRY GLUTEN (toast)

Tuna Melt

House tuna salad, Swiss cheese, griddled sourdough - Sell: \$16.99

10 min Main Target FC: 17%

Tuna Melt



INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Canned albacore tuna (drained)	120g	\$1.44
Mayonnaise	30g	\$0.18
Celery (fine diced)	30g	\$0.08
Red onion (fine diced)	20g	\$0.06
Swiss cheese	40g	\$0.80
Sourdough (thick sliced)	2 slices = 100g	\$0.60
Butter	15g	\$0.18
Total cost per serve		\$3.34

Cost per serve	\$3.34
Sell price	\$16.99
Food cost %	19.7%
Contribution margin	\$13.65

METHOD

- 1** House tuna salad (batch — make daily): Drain canned tuna thoroughly — press in a sieve to remove all liquid. Wet tuna makes soggy sandwiches and dilutes the mayo flavour. Mix with mayo, fine-diced celery, red onion, lemon juice, salt, black pepper. Season assertively. Refrigerate until service. This batch can be made at 7am and used through service.
- 2** Spread tuna salad generously on one slice of sourdough — pile it to at least 15mm thick. Lay Swiss cheese slices over the tuna. Close sandwich with second slice. Press firmly.
- 3** Butter outer faces of bread generously. Heat flat griddle to **155°C / 311°F** — medium heat, not high. High heat browns the bread before the cheese melts. Place sandwich, weight with a heavy spatula or sandwich press. Cook **3–4 minutes per side** until deep golden and Swiss cheese is visibly melted and starting to bubble at the edges.
- 4** Rest 1 minute. Cut diagonally. The cross-section should show generous tuna filling and melted cheese flowing. Serve with a side of half-sour pickle and extra mayo.

Chef's Tip: Use albacore tuna, not skipjack or generic canned tuna. Albacore has larger flakes, a milder flavour, and a noticeably better texture that makes the salad look and eat more premium. The cost difference per portion is \$0.40 — entirely recoverable in price and entirely visible in quality.

FISH (tuna) GLUTEN DAIRY EGGS (mayo)

Manhattan Clam Chowder

Red broth, littleneck clams, potato, celery, tomato · Sell: \$16.99

8 min (service) Main Target FC: 21% Batch

Manhattan Clam Chowder



INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Clams (chopped, canned)	100g	\$1.34
Clam juice (from can)	100ml	included
Canned crushed tomatoes	100g	\$0.34
Potato (diced, cooked)	100g	\$0.18
Celery (diced)	40g	\$0.10
Onion + garlic	50g + 5g	\$0.10
Bacon (diced)	30g	\$0.37
Fish stock + clam juice	200ml	\$0.22
Total cost per serve		\$2.65

Cost per serve	\$2.65
Sell price	\$16.99
Food cost %	15.6%
Contribution margin	\$14.34

METHOD

- 1 Render diced bacon in a heavy pot over medium heat until crispy and fat has released — **5 minutes**. Remove bacon, leave fat. Sauté onion, celery, garlic in the bacon fat until softened — **5 minutes**. The bacon fat provides the foundational flavour for the entire chowder.
- 2 Add crushed tomatoes, fish stock, and clam juice. Bring to a simmer at **90°C / 194°F**. Add diced potato and thyme. Simmer **15 minutes** until potato is tender but not falling apart. Season with salt, pepper, and Worcestershire sauce. The chowder base can be made to this point and refrigerated for up to 3 days.
- 3 Add chopped clams in the last **3 minutes only** — clams become tough and rubbery if cooked too long. They need just enough heat to warm through and release their briny liquor into the soup. This is the most critical timing in the dish.
- 4 Ladle into a warmed bowl. Top with reserved crispy bacon and a sprig of fresh thyme. Serve with oyster crackers on the side. The chowder should be tomato-red, briny-tasting, with visible chunks of potato and clam. Manhattan chowder should never be thick — it is a broth-based soup, not a cream soup.

Chef's Tip: The Manhattan vs New England chowder debate is real and passionate — never call it "New England style" by accident. Manhattan chowder is tomato-based and from New York. If a guest asks why no cream, explain it proudly: "Manhattan style — it is the original, it is lighter, and you can actually taste the clams." Make it a selling point.

FISH/SHELLFISH (clams) PORK (bacon) GLUTEN (crackers)

Bodega Breakfast Burrito

Scrambled eggs, black beans, pepper Jack, bacon, roasted salsa · Sell: \$16.99

10 min Main Target FC: 17%

Breakfast Burrito



INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Eggs (large)	3 × 55g = 165g	\$1.05
Flour tortilla (12-inch)	1 = 70g	\$0.28
Bacon (cooked, crumbled)	40g	\$0.50
Black beans (seasoned)	80g	\$0.18
Pepper Jack cheese (shredded)	40g	\$0.54
Roasted tomato salsa	40g	\$0.16
Butter	15g	\$0.18
Total cost per serve		\$2.89

Cost per serve	\$2.89
Sell price	\$16.99
Food cost %	17.0%
Contribution margin	\$14.10

METHOD

- 1 Warm flour tortilla on a flat griddle for **20 seconds each side** until pliable and slightly charred in spots. Cold tortillas crack when folded. Lay flat on a clean surface. Spread warm black beans across the centre third.
- 2 Scramble eggs in butter using the large-curd method: medium heat, slow folds, pulled off heat at 80% set. The eggs continue cooking on the residual heat of the pan. Slightly underdone eggs in a burrito are correct — they firm up further inside the tortilla's warmth. Overcooked eggs in a burrito become dry and rubbery.
- 3 Layer scrambled eggs over beans. Add crumbled bacon, shredded pepper Jack, salsa. Fold the burrito: fold in both sides, then roll tightly from the bottom up. Press seam-side down on the hot griddle for **60 seconds** to seal and create a crispy exterior that holds the wrap together.
- 4 Cut diagonally, serve immediately with additional salsa on the side. Wrap in deli paper if serving to-go — the paper maintains heat and is part of the bodega aesthetic.

Chef's Tip: The black beans are not an afterthought — season them properly. Drain canned black beans, warm in a pan with garlic, cumin, salt, and a pinch of smoked paprika for 5 minutes. Seasoned beans add a depth that unseasoned beans lack entirely. This 5-minute step is the difference between a bodega burrito that people crave and one they eat once.

EGGS GLUTEN DAIRY PORK (bacon)

New York Cheesecake

Dense cream cheese filling, graham cracker crust, no topping - Sell: \$9.99

3 min (service) Dessert Target FC: 12% Bake ahead

NY Cheesecake



INGREDIENTS (PER SLICE, 1/12 OF WHOLE CAKE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Cream cheese (full fat)	75g	\$0.92
Sour cream	20g	\$0.12
Sugar	25g	\$0.03
Eggs	0.4 eggs = 22g	\$0.14
Graham crackers (crust)	15g	\$0.12
Butter (crust)	6g	\$0.07
Total cost per slice		\$1.40

Cost per serve	\$1.40
Sell price	\$9.99
Food cost %	14.0%
Contribution margin	\$8.59

METHOD

- 1 Crust:** Crush graham crackers to fine crumbs. Mix with melted butter until it holds when pressed. Press into a greased 9-inch springform pan — press firmly and evenly up the sides 2cm. Pre-bake at **160°C / 320°F** for **10 minutes**. The pre-bake sets the crust so it does not absorb moisture from the filling and go soggy.
- 2** Beat cream cheese at room temperature (critical — cold cream cheese lumps and never fully smooths) until completely smooth — **5 minutes** on medium speed. Add sugar, beat 2 more minutes. Add sour cream. Add eggs one at a time, mixing on low speed after each addition. Low speed prevents incorporating air — air bubbles cause the cheesecake to rise then crack during cooling.
- 3** Pour filling over crust. Bake in a water bath (place springform pan in a larger pan with 3cm of hot water) at **150°C / 302°F** for **70–80 minutes**. The water bath regulates temperature and creates steam, preventing the surface from drying and cracking. The cheesecake is done when the edges are set and the centre jiggles like jelly — it will firm up completely on cooling.
- 4** Turn oven off, leave cheesecake inside with door cracked open for **1 hour**. This gradual cooling prevents the dramatic temperature change that causes cracking. Refrigerate minimum 4 hours, ideally overnight. Serve at room temperature — cheesecake straight from the fridge is too cold and the texture is stiff rather than creamy.

Chef's Tip: New York cheesecake has no flavouring except vanilla — no lemon curd, no berries, no chocolate swirl. The restraint is the point. The quality of the cream cheese is everything — use Philadelphia or an equivalent full-fat brand. Reduced-fat cream cheese has more water and produces a wet, loose, inferior cheesecake.

DAIRY EGGS GLUTEN (graham crust)

Black & White Cookie

Soft cakey cookie, half vanilla fondant, half chocolate fondant · Sell: \$5.99

2 min (service) Dessert Target FC: 10%

Black White Cookie



INGREDIENTS (PER COOKIE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Cake flour	40g	\$0.06
Sugar	30g	\$0.03
Butter	20g	\$0.24
Egg (1/2)	28g	\$0.18
Sour cream	15g	\$0.09
Vanilla fondant icing	20g	\$0.10
Chocolate fondant icing	20g	\$0.14
Total cost per cookie		\$0.84

Cost per serve	\$0.84
Sell price	\$5.99
Food cost %	14.0%
Contribution margin	\$5.15

METHOD (BATCH — BAKE 3× PER WEEK)

- 1 Cream butter and sugar until pale and fluffy. The lightness of the final cookie depends on this step — under-creamed butter produces a dense, heavy cookie. Add egg, sour cream, vanilla extract. Mix well. Sift in cake flour (not all-purpose — the lower protein content of cake flour is what gives the black and white cookie its distinctive soft, cakey crumb) and baking powder. Mix until just combined.
- 2 Scoop 60g rounds of batter onto parchment-lined trays, spacing 8cm apart — they spread significantly. Bake at **175°C / 347°F** for **12–14 minutes** until set and just beginning to colour at edges. They should not brown — a blonde cookie is correct. Cool completely on wire racks before icing.
- 3 Make fondant icings: vanilla — powdered sugar, corn syrup, vanilla, hot water to a thick, spreadable consistency. Chocolate — same base plus Dutch cocoa. The fondant must be thick enough to set firm within 10 minutes; thin fondant stays sticky and smears when handled.
- 4 Ice the flat bottom of the cookie (the smooth side faces up for icing). Using a small offset spatula, ice one half vanilla, the other half chocolate — with a clean, straight dividing line exactly down the middle. The precision of this line is the hallmark of a properly made black and white cookie.

Chef's Tip: The black and white cookie is uniquely New York — it exists almost nowhere else in American food culture. When guests ask about it, tell them: "It is from the Lower East Side Jewish bakeries, goes back to the 1900s. Jerry Seinfeld called it the symbol of racial harmony. It is just a very good cookie." This story, delivered with a straight face, sells cookies.

GLUTEN DAIRY EGGS

Chocolate Babka Slice

Swirled enriched chocolate brioche, cinnamon · Sell: \$7.99

3 min · Dessert · Target FC: 11%

Chocolate Babka



INGREDIENTS (PER SLICE, 1/10 LOAF)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Bread flour	50g	\$0.06
Butter (enriched dough)	18g	\$0.22
Egg	0.5 = 28g	\$0.18
Sugar + yeast + milk	15g+2g+20ml	\$0.12
Dark chocolate (filling)	20g	\$0.28
Cocoa powder + cinnamon	5g	\$0.06
Total cost per slice		\$0.92

Cost per serve	\$0.92
Sell price	\$7.99
Food cost %	11.5%
Contribution margin	\$7.07

METHOD (BATCH — BAKE 2× PER WEEK)

- 1 Make enriched dough: dissolve yeast in warm milk (35°C / 95°F). Mix flour, sugar, salt. Add milk-yeast, eggs. Mix on medium 3 minutes. Add softened butter in small pieces over 5 minutes — this slow addition gives the butter time to incorporate into the gluten network without making the dough greasy. The dough is ready when it is smooth, elastic, and pulls cleanly from the bowl sides. First rise: 1 hour at room temperature.
- 2 Roll dough to a 40×30cm rectangle, 3mm thick. Spread chocolate filling (melted dark chocolate + cocoa + cinnamon + sugar) to the edges. Roll tightly from the long edge into a log. Cut the log lengthwise in half — exposing the swirls. Twist the two halves around each other, swirl-side facing out. Place in a greased loaf tin.
- 3 Proof 1 hour at room temperature until the dough has risen to fill the tin. Bake at 170°C / 338°F for 35–40 minutes until deep brown and hollow-sounding when tapped. Brush with simple syrup immediately on exit from oven — the syrup creates the glossy, sticky exterior and keeps the babka moist for days.
- 4 Cool 30 minutes before slicing. Slice 3cm thick — thinner and the swirl structure falls apart. Serve at room temperature or slightly warm (30 seconds in a 150°C oven). Never microwave — microwave heat makes enriched dough tough.

Chef's Tip: Babka freezes beautifully — slice the entire loaf, wrap individual slices in cling film, freeze. Defrost at room temperature 20 minutes or warm in a 150°C oven for 8 minutes. This gives you a zero-waste, consistent dessert that is always available even when fresh batches have sold through.

GLUTEN · DAIRY · EGGS



Bottomless Deli Coffee

\$4.00

INGREDIENT	AMOUNT	COST
Filter coffee (batch brew)	300ml	\$0.28
Creamer + sugar (optional)	—	\$0.04
Total cost		\$0.32

Food cost %	8.0%
Contribution	\$3.68

Strong filter brew in a proper diner mug. No artisan pretensions — just good, strong coffee that keeps getting refilled. This is the highest volume drink on your menu. Brew fresh every 30 minutes.

Classic Egg Cream



Classic Egg Cream

\$5.50

INGREDIENT	AMOUNT	COST
Fox's U-Bet chocolate syrup	30ml	\$0.22
Whole milk (cold)	60ml	\$0.10
Seltzer (cold, forceful stream)	200ml	\$0.14
Total cost		\$0.46

Food cost %	8.4%
Contribution	\$5.04

Method matters: add syrup first, then cold milk, then blast in the seltzer with force — this creates the foamy white head. Stir once from the bottom. Must be served immediately; it collapses within 2 minutes. Contains no eggs despite the name.



Fresh Squeezed OJ

\$6.00

INGREDIENT	AMOUNT	COST
Valencia oranges	4 medium = 480g	\$0.80
Total cost		\$0.80

Food cost %	13.3%
Contribution	\$5.20

Squeeze to order — pre-squeezed OJ loses its bright, fresh flavour within 20 minutes. The time difference between

fresh-squeezed and 2-hour-old OJ is immediately tasted. This is the most visible morning upsell you have.

Rich Hot Chocolate



Rich Hot Chocolate

\$5.50

INGREDIENT	AMOUNT	COST
Dutch cocoa powder	15g	\$0.18
Whole milk	280ml	\$0.48
Sugar	15g	\$0.02
Total cost		\$0.68

Food cost %	12.4%
Contribution	\$4.82

Whisk cocoa and sugar with 30ml cold milk to a paste first — this prevents lumps. Heat remaining milk to 70°C / 158°F, whisk in paste. Dutch process cocoa gives a deeper, less acidic flavour. Serve in the biggest mug you have.

Cream Soda Float



Cream Soda Float

\$7.50

INGREDIENT	AMOUNT	COST
Vanilla ice cream	2 scoops = 120g	\$0.60
Cream soda	250ml	\$0.28
Total cost		\$0.88

Food cost %	11.7%
Contribution	\$6.62

Put ice cream in glass first, pour cold cream soda slowly down the side of the glass to reduce foam. Top with the excess foam over the rim. Serve with a long spoon and a wide straw. The float is a visual-first drink — present it at height for maximum impact.

Iced Tea



Iced Tea & Lemon

\$4.50

INGREDIENT	AMOUNT	COST
Strong black tea (batch brewed)	300ml	\$0.12
Simple syrup (side)	15ml	\$0.04
Lemon slice + ice	—	\$0.06
Total cost		\$0.22

Food cost %	4.9%
Contribution	\$4.28

Brew strong (double strength), cool, refrigerate. Serve over ice with lemon and simple syrup on the side. Your second-highest margin drink after the deli coffee. Push both proactively.

5

Kitchen Prep Flow — 7:00am to 3:00pm

Team: Head Cook (HC) + Line Cook (LC) + Steward (ST). NYC Bodega morning service is fast and high-volume — the morning prep window is essential to achieving sub-8-minute ticket times through the full breakfast and lunch rush.

	Head Cook	Line Cook	Steward
07:00–07:30	Temp check all units — log. Fridge: 1–4°C . Pull brisket from fridge, begin reheating in jus at low heat. Start batch deli coffee brewing. Taste matzo ball soup from previous day — reheat to 74°C+ .	Station setup — flat-top on, set to 180°C . Pull all deli meats: pastrami, lox, bacon, ham. Check slicing dates. Set up egg station: crack, season, hold in ramekins. Check pickle supply — all three types.	Sanitise all surfaces. Set up dishwasher. Grind coffee. Set tables, stock condiments: ketchup, mustard, hot sauce, Tabasco. Fill cream and sugar holders. Stack napkins and cutlery.
07:30–09:00	Make daily batch hollandaise — test consistency, hold in bain-marie at 55°C . Make fresh tuna salad (100g mayo, season, refrigerate). Check cheesecake and babka inventory — pull from fridge to come to room temp.	Parboil home fries potatoes (8 min, drain, refrigerate). Caramelize onions for knish (15 min). Cook matzo balls if needed — simmer 35–40 min. Slice cold brisket into 200g portions, store in jus. Pre-cook bacon in batches, hold warm.	Juice oranges — stock 8 serves. Set up egg cream station with Fox's syrup, cold milk, seltzer gun. Ice all drink glasses. Prepare simple syrup for iced tea. Pre-set 6 tables with menus and condiments.
09:00–11:00 Breakfast Service	Runs pass — calls orders, checks every plate. Fires egg benedicts (most time-sensitive item — 12 min). Monitors hollandaise — refresh if it begins to thicken or cool. Manages ticket board, ensures no order exceeds 12 min.	Executes bodega egg & cheese (7 min), breakfast burritos (10 min), bagel boards (8 min). Runs smash burger station if ordered at breakfast. Maintains flat-top temperature. Communicates delays proactively to HC.	Continuous drink running — deli coffee refills proactively before guests ask. Runs food to tables. Clears and washes constantly. Monitors coffee — brew fresh batch every 30 minutes. Alert HC at low inventory of any item.
11:00–11:30 Transition	Adjust mise en place for lunch mains. Top up brisket — ensure it is hot and moist. New hollandaise batch for brunch orders. Quick team check: ticket times from breakfast, what items ran slow.	Break down breakfast station. Set up for Reuben and mains service: portion pastrami 120g piles, slice Swiss, prep sauerkraut. Batch clam chowder — heat to 85°C . Ensure enough home fries batch for lunch.	Full table reset. Restock all stations. Check all pickle levels — critical for lunch. Restock dessert counter: cheesecake slices, babka slices plated and ready. Refill all drink stations.
11:30–14:30 Lunch Service	Runs pass with particular attention to Reuben and brisket sandwich timing. Monitors grill/flat-top temps. Ensures pastrami is steamed to order — never pre-steamed and held. Calls desserts proactively at table 10-minute mark.	Executes all mains: Reuben (12 min), pastrami on rye (8 min), steak & eggs (14 min), smash burgers (10 min). Maintains station cleanliness between orders. Communicates when brisket is running low to HC.	High-volume dish turnaround. Refill coffee station — lunch guests want consistent refills. Run food immediately — hot sandwiches decline fast. Assist with dessert plating during service gaps.
14:30–15:00 Close	Cool all hot batch items: clam chowder, brisket jus — ice bath to below 21°C within 2 hours . Label and date all containers. Write tomorrow's prep list. Note what ran out, what was over-prepped.	Break down stations, clean flat-top with griddle block, scrub pans. Wrap and refrigerate deli meats. Dispose of tuna salad older than 1 day. Clean slicer thoroughly — this is a critical food safety step.	Full kitchen clean — floors, surfaces. Empty all bins. Sanitise all contact surfaces including slicers, cutting boards, utensils. Final fridge temp check — log all units. All fridges: 1–4°C before leaving.

6 Financial Forecast — US Market (NYC)

Assumptions: 35 seats · Breakfast avg spend \$38 · Lunch avg spend \$52 · 26 trading days/month · NYC rent premium applied · Staff: Head Cook \$22/hr, Line Cook \$18/hr, Steward \$15/hr, FOH x2 \$16/hr

Daily Revenue Projection

Service	Covers	Avg Spend	Daily Revenue
Breakfast (7am–11am)	32	\$38	\$1,216
Lunch (11:30am–2:30pm)	48	\$52	\$2,496
Daily Total			\$3,712
Monthly (26 days)			\$96,512

Monthly Cost Breakdown

Cost Category	Calculation	Monthly Cost	% Revenue
Food & Beverage (COGS)	$\$96,512 \times 22\%$	\$21,233	22.0%
Head Cook — \$22/hr × 8 × 26	$22 \times 8 \times 26$	\$4,576	4.7%
Line Cook — \$18/hr × 8 × 26	$18 \times 8 \times 26$	\$3,744	3.9%
Steward — \$15/hr × 8 × 26	$15 \times 8 \times 26$	\$3,120	3.2%
FOH x2 — \$16/hr × 8 × 26 × 2	$16 \times 8 \times 26 \times 2$	\$6,656	6.9%
Total Labour		\$18,096	18.8%
Rent (NYC premium)	Fixed	\$5,000	5.2%
Utilities	Fixed	\$900	0.9%
Supplies & Packaging	Fixed	\$500	0.5%
Misc / Contingency	Fixed	\$400	0.4%
Total Fixed Overhead		\$6,800	7.0%
Total All Costs		\$46,129	47.8%
NET PROFIT (at capacity)		\$50,383	52.2%

Break-Even Analysis

Daily fixed costs: Labour \$696 + Overhead \$262 = **\$958/day**

Break-even = $\$958 \div (\$45 \text{ avg spend} \times 78\% \text{ GP}) = \$958 \div \$35.10 = \sim 28 \text{ covers to break even per day}$

With a 35-seat room running at 75% average utilisation, you typically cross break-even before noon. Every afternoon cover is pure net profit contribution.

3-Month Ramp Projection

Month	Capacity	Monthly Revenue	Est. Net Profit
Month 1 — Learning	60%	\$57,907	~\$9,500
Month 2 — Building	80%	\$77,210	~\$26,000
Month 3 — Cruising	100%	\$96,512	~\$50,383

7 Service Training Module

SCRIPT 1 — THE FOOD STORY UPSELL

"The pastrami on rye — we steam it to order, so it is completely different from cold deli meat. It takes about 8 minutes and it is genuinely one of the best sandwiches you can eat. Shall I put one in for you?"

Why it works: Technique storytelling (steamed to order) differentiates from every other deli. The 8-minute callout manages expectations while building anticipation.

SCRIPT 2 — THE CLASSIC COMBO

"Can I grab you an egg cream with that? It is chocolate syrup, cold milk, and seltzer — a New York thing from the 1900s, no eggs in it despite the name. It is \$5.50 and it goes perfectly with a sandwich."

Why it works: Story + mystery (no eggs?) + price anchoring. Guests who have never had an egg cream almost always try it when told this story.

SCRIPT 3 — THE DESSERT PLANT

"Quick note — we only have a few slices of the black and white cookie left today. Want me to set one aside? It is \$5.99, comes with the check."

Why it works: Scarcity + the word "set aside" sounds like a service act, not a sales pitch. Plant this with every table at order time.

SCRIPT 4 — THE PICKLE PLATE OPENER

"While you look at the menu — our house pickle plate is \$9.99, we make the half-sours in-house, they take 3 days to ferment. Really good starter if you want something to nibble. Want one?"

Why it works: The 3-day fermentation detail communicates craft. The pickle plate is your highest-margin starter at 10.4% food cost.

SCRIPT 5 — THE REGULAR BUILDER

"Are you in the neighbourhood? We do a Reuben Wednesday special — it is the full sandwich with a bowl of matzo ball soup at a reduced price. Worth coming back for if you are local."

Why it works: Gives a specific reason to return on a specific day. Wednesday specials create a weekly ritual that builds habitual regulars.

Table Timing Guide

Time	Action
0:00	Greet within 60 seconds. "Welcome in, grab any seat." Water and menu. Pour coffee if they look like they want it.
1:30	Offer and take drink orders. Offer fresh OJ proactively: "Our oranges are squeezed to order — it is \$6, want one while you decide?"
3:00	For first-timers: quick 20-second menu tour. "Our most popular: Reuben, brisket sandwich, steak and eggs. The egg cream is a New York classic worth trying."
5:00	Take food order. Use Script 2 (egg cream pairing) and Script 4 (pickle plate opener). Deploy Script 3 (dessert plant) every single time.
14:00	Check in 2 min after food arrives. Refill coffee without being asked. Ask how everything is — look at the plate.
22:00	Dessert check. Offer cheesecake or babka with coffee. "Want a cheesecake slice? We make it in-house, it is not the light airy type — it is proper New York dense."
30:00	Drop bill on request. Use Script 5 (regular builder) with every first-timer. Say goodbye by name if you learned it.
+0	After they leave: note any regulars in the notebook. Write name, order, day of visit.

8 Customer Retention System

The Bodega Principle: The corner bodega has survived supermarkets, delivery apps, and gentrification for one reason: the owner knows your name. That relationship — "the usual?" — is worth more than any loyalty app. Build it from day one.

3-Visit Rule:

Visit 1: Remember their face and order. Note it in your head.

Visit 2: "I think you came in last week — I'm [name], what's yours?" Write it down immediately after they leave.

Visit 3: "The pastrami on rye, extra mustard?" — You just created a regular for life.

5 VIP Micro-Moments

1. The Coffee Before They Ask. If a regular has always had bottomless coffee, fill it before they glance at the mug. This anticipation communicates that you are genuinely paying attention.

2. The New Pickle Heads-Up. When your half-sours hit their 3-day mark and are at peak crunchiness, tell a regular: "The half-sours just hit perfect today — really want you to try one." Give a sample. Cost: \$0.18. Value: they come back specifically to try fresh batches.

3. The Complimentary Egg Cream. Once a month for a loyal regular, send an egg cream with the check. No ceremony needed — just a small note: "On us today. Thanks for being here." Cost: \$0.46. ROI: priceless.

4. Their Booth. If a regular has a preferred table, remember it. "Your booth is free" before they even think to ask. This four-word sentence builds loyalty that cannot be bought with a discount.

5. The Pickle Insider. Tell a regular what pickle is just ready: "The full-sours hit 14 days today — if you like them really sour, this is the day." Making guests feel like insiders makes them feel like they belong.

Complaint Recovery — 3 Steps

Step 1 — Listen and absorb. Full eye contact. Do not speak until they finish. Do not explain. The deli culture is direct and no-nonsense — match that energy by listening completely before responding.

Step 2 — Own it straight. "You're right. That's not what we're about. I'm sorry." NYC directness: no hedging, no passive voice, no "I understand your frustration." Short, direct, genuine.

Step 3 — Fix and bring back. Remake, replace, or refund immediately. Then: "Your coffee and cookie are on us today. Come back this week — I want to make it right." The "come back this week" is the most important phrase: it converts a complaint into a return visit.

Social Media — 5 Best Shots

1. Pastrami steam shot: Film the moment steaming pastrami is lifted from the steamer — the cloud of aromatic steam rising from the glistening meat is one of the most viscerally appetising food videos possible. 15-second Reel. Do it weekly.

2. Reuben cross-section: Cut the Reuben in the kitchen before plating, photograph the cross-section showing pink pastrami, orange thousand island, pale sauerkraut, golden cheese on dark rye. This image communicates everything about quality in one frame.

3. Egg cream pour: Film the seltzer being blasted into the egg cream, the white foam rising dramatically over the rim. This is a drink that looks spectacular on video and has the New York story attached.

4. Pickle plate overhead: Three pickle types in distinct colours against a white plate from directly above — food photography that practically shoots itself. Post every time you get a new batch in peak condition.

5. Cheesecake fork-cut: Film a fork cutting through a slice of New York cheesecake — the dense, slow resistance and clean break communicates quality texture instantly.

EXAMPLE CAPTION — PASTRAMI

This is what 7 days of work looks like. [Hook]

We cure our pastrami in-house. Salt brine, black pepper, coriander, garlic. Then it smokes. Then it steams to order — every single time, never cold from a bag. The result is something you can only get at a real deli. We are a real deli. [Story]

Open daily 7am. Come hungry. [CTA]

Neighbourhood Anchor Strategy

Partner 1 — Local office buildings: Visit every office building within 3 blocks. Offer a "deli catering" package: Reuben + soup sets for 8–15 people, pre-ordered by 9am for noon delivery. One committed office account is \$600–900 per week. Bring sample boxes — a warm egg and cheese and a slice of cheesecake gets you through more doors than any brochure.

Partner 2 — Gym or fitness studio: Gyms generate high-protein hungry people at 7–9am. Offer a gym-partner deal: their members get a free deli coffee with any breakfast order. They promote you on their social; you promote them with a small menu callout. Costs you \$0.32 per customer acquired.

Partner 3 — Local newspaper or publication: Reach out to local food writers and neighbourhood blogs. Invite them in. Feed them well. A single "Best Sandwiches in [neighbourhood]" mention can change your trajectory permanently.

Wednesday Reuben Special: Every Wednesday, the full Reuben + matzo ball soup combo at a set price. Post it every Tuesday evening on Instagram. After 6 weeks, you will have guests who schedule Wednesday lunches specifically. Weekly rituals build the most durable customer loyalty.